

magazine



wideangle
Devdutt Pattanaik on
Narada, the itinerant sage

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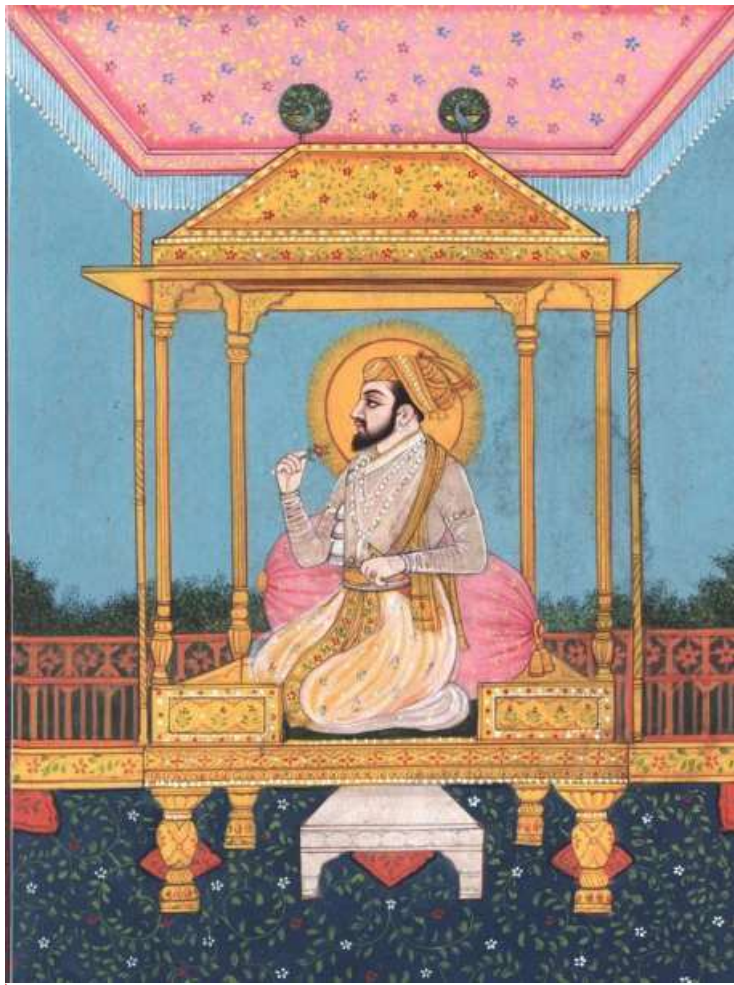
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A reproduction of a 17th century miniature showing Mughal emperor Shah Jahan on the peacock throne.

Half a millennium later, the dynasty's legacy endures via art, culture and more, even as political mandarins do their best to erase this vital history

LIVING WITH THE MUGHALS

Serish Nanisetti
serish.n@thehindu.co.in

On a hot, wind-swept April day 500 years ago, a tall, lean man and his army of 15,000 soldiers waited in battle formation on the dusty fields of Panipat, less than 100 km from Delhi. Facing them was the wary yet formidable force of Delhi Sultan Ibrahim Lodi, nearly 10 times larger, with 1,00,000 soldiers and 1,000 war elephants.

The invading army, led by Zahiruddin Babur, a Chagatai Turk who traced his lineage

to both Timur and Genghis Khan, had reached Panipat on April 12, 1526. Lodi's forces probed and provoked the enemy camp, even taking heads as trophies, but to no avail. "...they broke ranks they had maintained and as though undecided whether to stand or proceed, were able to do neither," wrote Babur in his memoir about the Sultan's army.

Writers and scholars recommend books on the Mughals (page 3) and palaces and lesser-known monuments (page 4).

At around 7 a.m. on April 21, Lodi's elephants and soldiers stirred and moved forward, trumpeting and racing. Babur's Turkic troops, who drank, sang, killed, and wrote poetry, were waiting. As they wheeled to rain arrows from both sides, "the enemy's right and left flanks were so crowded into one spot that they were not able to go forward or to find a way to escape," wrote Babur. "At noon, the enemy was overcome and

vanquished to the delight of our friends. By God's grace and generosity such a difficult action was made easy for us, and such a numerous army was ground into the dust in half a day," he exulted. The victorious army would race to Delhi and Agra.

Colonisers are not celebrated by the colonised. But when they change not just the history of the conquered land, but also the art, culture, language, food, clothes and architecture, it becomes something else. The Battle of Panipat would change the history of India over the next 500 years.

"The first thing that Babur does after winning the war is not a massacre or a raid on treasury. He does neither. He reaches

Delhi and circumambulates the grave of Sufi saint Nizamuddin Aulia.

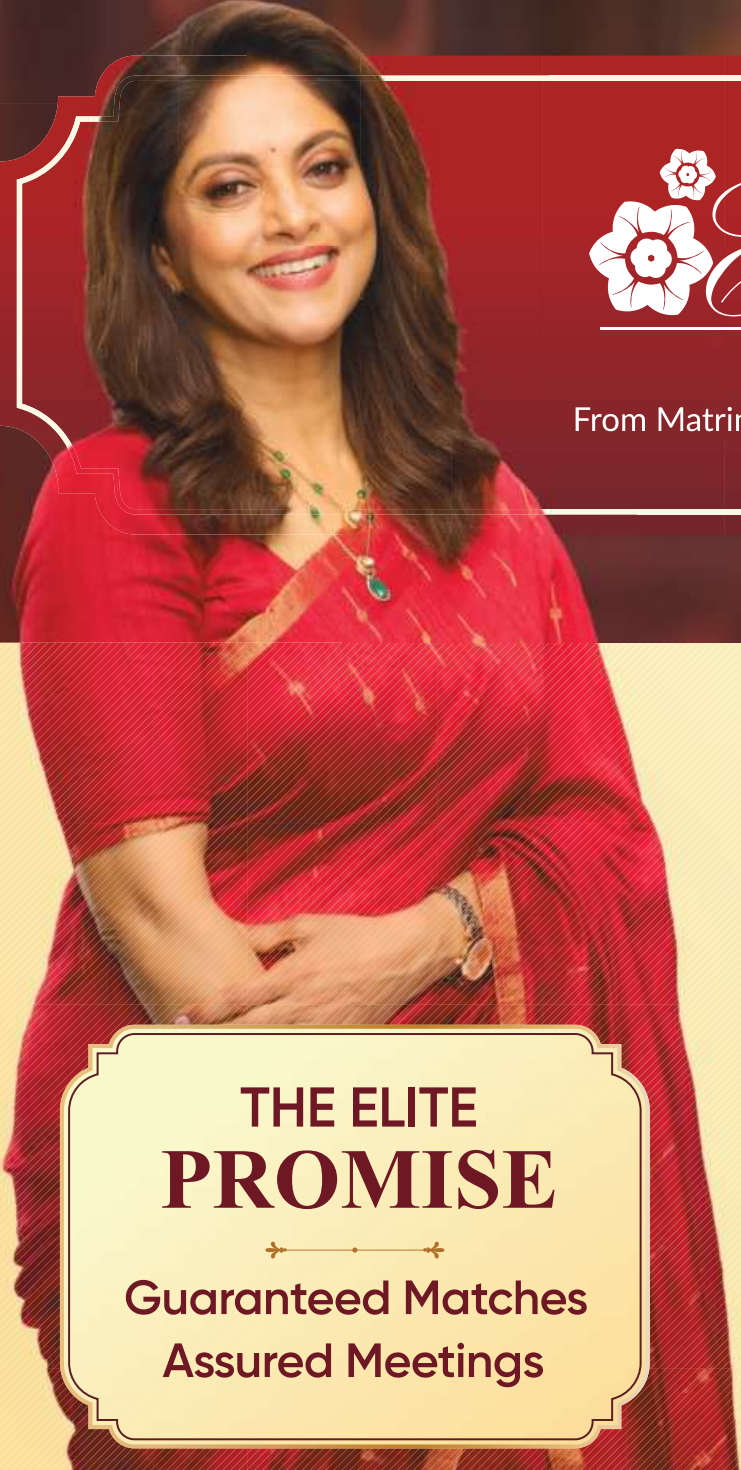
There, he gets a poem inscribed on the grave of [mystic and Aulia's disciple] Amir Khusro," says Ratish Nanda, chief executive officer of the Aga Khan Trust for Culture (AKTC).

Remnants of the past
It has been just under two years since the Humayun's Tomb Museum – a sunken structure within the 16th century Humayun's Tomb complex in the national capital – opened its doors to visitors. Developed by AKTC in partnership with the Archaeological Survey of India, the museum brings alive the story of Babur's son, Humayun, and the dynasty he helped establish – one that, over 232 years and five months, evolved into the subcontinent we now call India.

At its core, the museum's narrative is less about conquest than about the idea of empire. "Babur loses control of India, then 20 years later, Humayun gains control and does exactly the same. He inscribes a poem in honour of Khusro. We have Akbar telling Prince Phillip II of Spain and Shah Abbas of Persia that he is a better emperor than all of them because he has 880 kinds of people living in his kingdom," says Nanda.

CONTINUED ON
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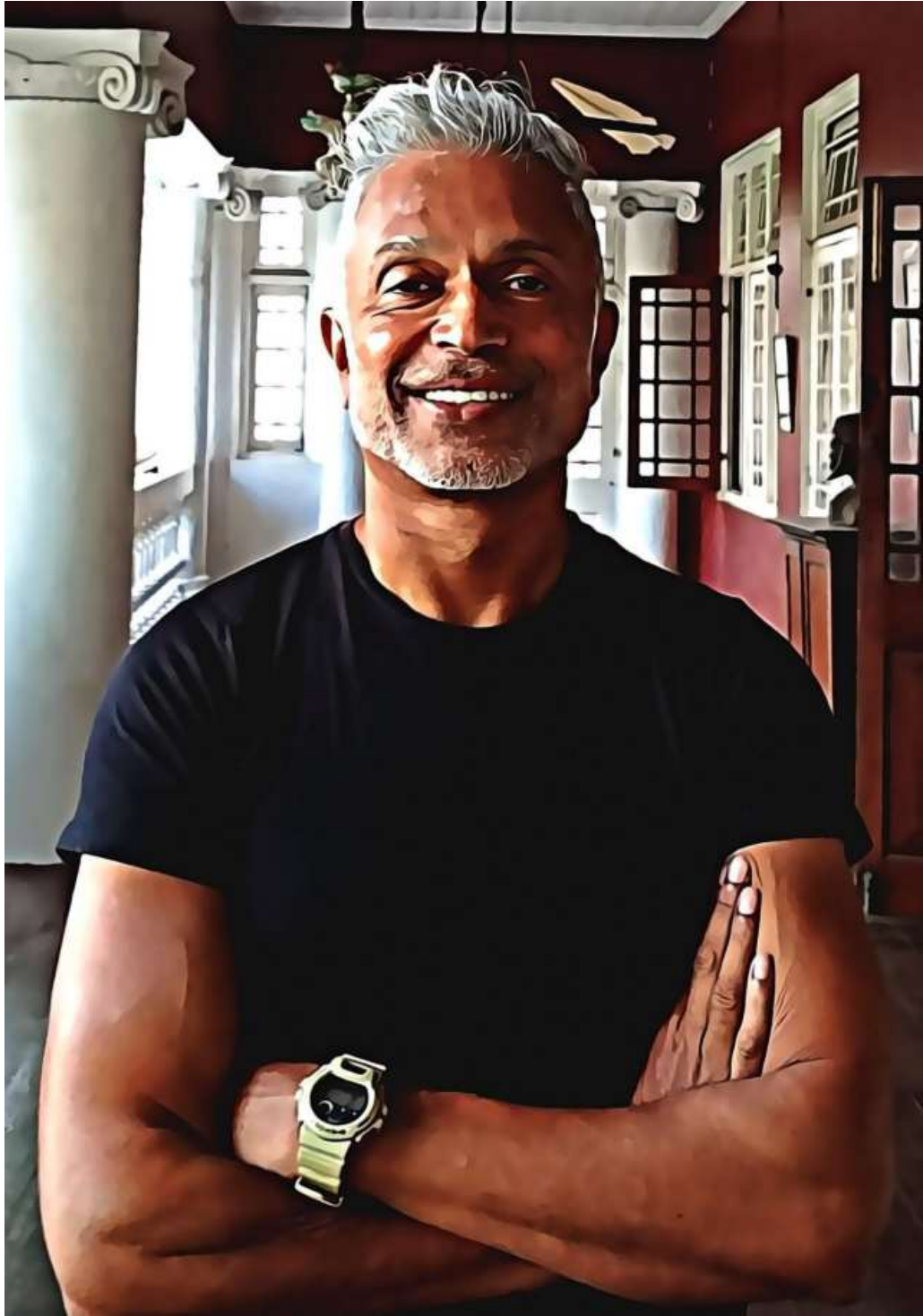
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IN CONVERSATION

ASHOK
FERREY'S
HOMIECOMING

In his wry yet heartfelt new novel set entirely in Sri Lanka, the author uses humour to reflect on trauma

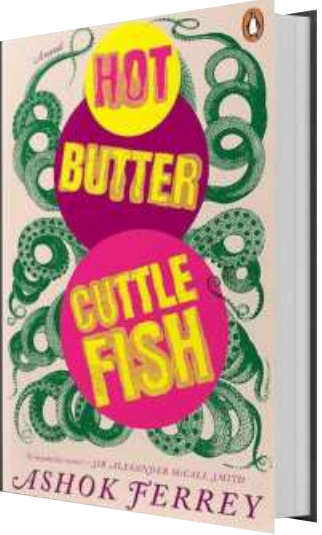
Chittajit Mitra

Writing about COVID-19 in fiction is no easy task, especially without letting the narrative slip into something heavy or grim. Award-winning Sri Lankan writer Ashok Ferry uses humour to navigate the subject in his new book *Hot Butter Cuttlefish* (published by Penguin). He argues that humour remains an underrated literary tool, particularly in South Asian writing. At the Ceylon Literary & Arts Festival in February, where we met, he reflected on what it means to be Sri Lankan, describing his approach as a “cowardly” way of presenting it to readers. Edited excerpts:

Question: *What's the story behind the title of the book?*
Answer: We in Sri Lanka take foreign things and adopt and adapt them. And we get very fiercely protective about them. Hot butter cuttlefish is every Sri Lankan's favourite dish. You go anywhere, you

ask for it. We also fondly imagine it's Chinese. I'm sure it was originally, but if you went to China now and asked for hot butter cuttlefish, they'll probably look at you strangely. So we have appropriated it.

In a way, the book is about COVID-19 and how we reacted to it. We fondly imagined COVID-19 as a foreign thing. Of course it was. It may have come from China, but it became very much our



problem. You couldn't blame it on anyone else after a while. So, this is just a metaphor for that transference of culture.

Q: *Many of your books draw clear connections between Sri Lanka and other parts of the world. When you began this one, did you consciously decide to focus solely on Sri Lanka?*
A: No, but there is a grain of truth to your assumption because the last book was very England-centric, it was very Brixton and Oxford, and so on. And I thought, I need to return to my roots here. So,



In Sri Lanka, when it's good, it's very good. When it's bad, it's very bad. We're just not capable of that middle road, which is funny, because we're a Buddhist country

Ashok Ferrey won the Gratiaen Prize, Sri Lanka's highest literary honour, for his 2021 novel *The Unmarriageable Man*.

this book is like *Serendipity* (2009), my very first novel, a crazy novel, but set squarely in Sri Lanka. And I thought to myself, time to return home with this book.

Q: *Before the novel begins, there are three news articles about COVID-19. Why is that?*
A: I have to tell you, I asked my publishers if we could take those out? Because I get into a lot of trouble. And they said, absolutely not! You have to keep them because they put the story in context. People think that I write fairy tales, that everything I write is imagined. Wrong. So much of it is absolutely life here. And you realise that Sri Lanka is one of those magical places, magical in not a very flattering way. You know, the sort of things that you can't believe actually happen.

Q: *It is often said that great tragedies also give birth to great art. Would you say that's the case with your book as well?*
A: I just do what I do to the best of my rather poor ability. When I wrote *Serendipity*, it was in the last months of the war. I was in a really bad state. I thought, this is not a war, nobody can win. They're bombing each other out. And it's probably my funniest book.

When COVID-19 happened, it left us abandoned. We were like a motherless child. And the mother to whom we paid taxes all our lives, suddenly decided to up and go and say, that's it, son.

As a man, you feel doubly responsible as you have a duty to care for and protect the people around you, and you can't do that when there's no cooking gas, when there's no rice, no eggs. In Sri Lanka, when it's good, it's very good. When it's bad, it's very bad. We're just not capable of that middle road, which is funny, because we're a Buddhist country.

Q: *Do you think that the wit and humour in your books allows you to capture human experiences better?*
A: Yes, there are two things to this. I think, first of all, I'm a real coward and I never face problems squarely. I always work around the sides, and humour is a good way of doing that and getting to the destination. The second, it also transforms from journalism into this other kind of query: “What did he mean by that? Hang on a minute, is he laughing at me or is he not?” All too often, I am laughing. I think in South Asia we take our literature very seriously, and rightly so, because we have such a huge canon of fantastic literature like the Upanishads, *Ramayana*, *Mahabharata*, and even in Sri Lanka, we have the erotic poetry from the 16th century. Because of that, there are very few humorous writers in South Asia. There are plenty of jesters. Mostly in the Parliament, of course. So I thought why shouldn't I play to my strengths? I always say, anybody can make you cry. Very few people can make you laugh.

The interviewer is an independent writer, journalist and translator based in Allahabad.

WORLD BOOK AND COPYRIGHT DAY | APRIL 23

Notes from the
black box

How translation is the quiet force that keeps literature alive across languages

Mini Krishnan

A picture theory of language says it is the link between words and the real world. It starts very early. One points to a cow and says to a toddler: “Look – cow. Say it? Say ‘cow’” Thereafter, it is unlikely that the child will point to a cow and say ‘tree’. Why? Its caretakers have made sure that the object-word pair has been imprinted.

The theory expands to say that behind all meaningful thoughts that people have are arrangements of pictures achieved by the plod of hard work and the flight of the imagination. Feelings and emotions are the invisible ‘gesso’ or primer before words are painted on the canvas of the mind.

What happens when the literary produce of one language has to be relocated in another linguistic space? The trade between languages and cultures is occupied by translation – surely one of the most fatiguing exercises of the human brain – and to quote Lakshmi Holmstrom, achieved by continuously letting poetry win without allowing scholarship to lose. Success, after a great struggle completely invisible to readers and sometimes even publishers trained to help with weeds and stones, is usually a carefully crafted compromise.

Translation has always been a controversial literary form viewed with suspicion and as a sort of “service” industry instead of the hugely creative operation it is, calling for imagination, stamina, patience and negotiation skills. Only recently, and in the face of international prizes, has translation been granted the dignity of an original work. A few months ago, International Booker-winning author Banu Mushtaq argued that for a translator to lay claim to her own work in English was a criminal offence; that even the product of [International Booker-winning translator] Deepa Bhashthi's mind belonged to her author, Banu Mushtaq. Could we have a show of hands?

Living off the differences

Who owns a translation? This question has been on the boil for at least 2,000 years. A couple of agrarian metaphors about it are worth sharing. England's greatest medieval poet Geoffrey Chaucer, who was a translator before he wrote poetry, said that translation is like ploughing an old field to produce new corn; and John Dryden, who called translators ‘the metaphraser’s’, said that translators are like labourers who toil in other men's vineyards.

These two descriptions imply very hard work to produce something visible from something that lies hidden. The Quebec Declaration on Literary Translation and Translators (translated by Sherry Simon) - Item 3 reads: “Respectful of authors and original texts, translators are nevertheless creators in their own right. They seek not only to reproduce a literary work but to

move the work forward, to expand its presence in the world.” Item 6 says, “As creative writers with specific skills and knowledge, translators must be shown respect and consulted for all questions related to their work. Translations belong to those who create them.”

“Who is creative?” asked Howard Gardner and answered the question himself. “He who affects peoples' lives.” Further, the shifts over time in the selection and style of translations are important aspects of studying a language as part of its history of literary criticism. The condensed idea: translators live off the differences between languages and struggle to eliminate the same. How can they not be creative?

Moving forward as a community
Poet A.K. Ramanujan said that translators are artists on oath – sworn to not betray either the source language or the target language they are engaged in manipulating, bending and mulching to produce a third language which carries the energies of both. Turning from the greats to the transformers amongst us, Jhumpa Lahiri reaches back to Greek mythology, to the story of Echo who is punished with partial expression and deprived of her own voice and words. But, says, Lahiri, she who translates converts this “Echo” punishment into a challenge, a joy. “Nowhere to be seen, always to be heard,” is the description of Echo in the original Greek poem.

Lahiri goes on to say that that is why while works of art, however imperfect, are regarded as definitive, a translation can always be replaced by a later one that appeals to another time, another generation. And then she says something unforgettable: “Translations are dispensable but the truth is also that they are indispensable” because, crucially for us, and critically, they sustain great works.

In a multilingual country like India, translation is a vital component of national identity and just as we need to preserve and develop our art forms, music and literature, not to mention forests, rivers and monuments, we need to preserve and retrieve our literatures in the various regional languages and bring them to a space where we can all benefit from our shared history. The translating community of India – researchers, librarians, translators, dictionary-makers, teachers of literature, editors, salesmen, and booksellers – all play a stupendous civilisational role. And, of course, our readers who anonymously carry us forward.

World Book Day would never have been possible without the work of the facilitators of contact cultures: translators.

The writer coordinates a translation project for the Tamil Nadu Textbook and Educational Services Corporation.

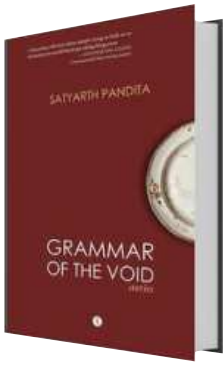


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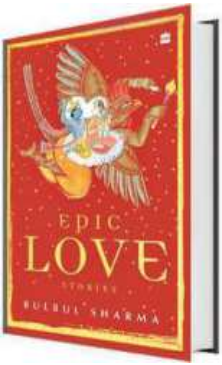
Grammar of the Void
Satyarth Pandita

Hawakal Publishers
₹400
This debut collection of short stories explores the inner lives of people shaped by moral doubt, grief, exile and psychological fracture. Across realist and speculative settings, the stories examine silence, memory and absence, tracing how individuals endure trauma.



Epic Love Stories
Bulbul Sharma

Harper Fiction
₹499
Sixteen timeless romances from Indian myths and legends, featuring devas, asuras, kings, queens and apsaras, showcase love in all its forms. A painter, children's author and food writer, Sharma brings her evocative yet gentle touch to this collection.



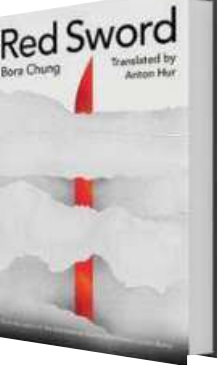
Son of Nobody
Yann Martel

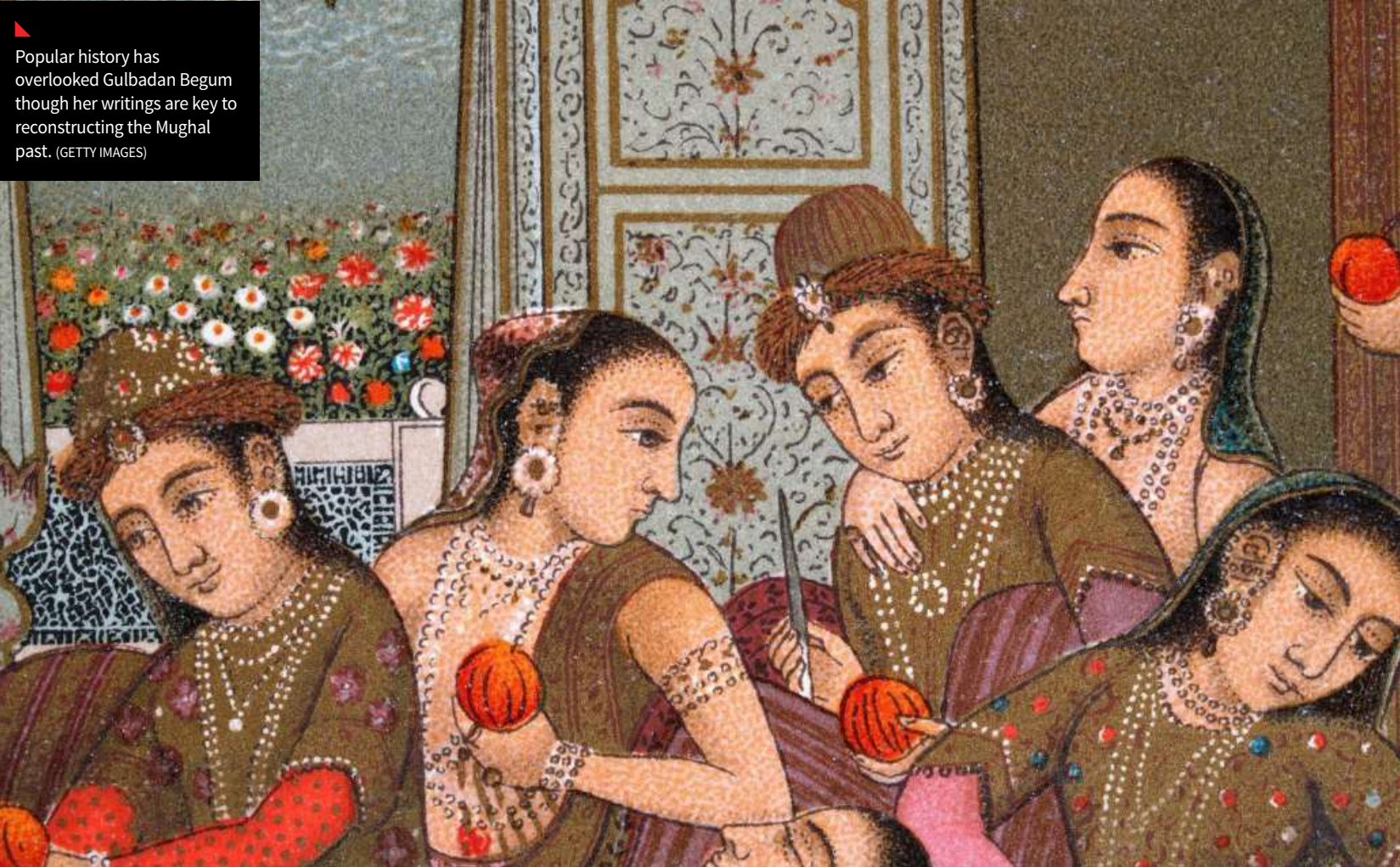
Canongate
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The *Life of Pi* author's new book re-examines the Trojan War through two commoners: an ancient soldier and a modern-day scholar. As the past and present intertwine, Martel looks at how stories become facts, the price we pay to share them, and then live with them.



Red Sword
Bora Chung, trs Anton Hur

PanMacmillan
₹399
When a woman is forced into battle on a distant, war-torn planet, she unravels the truth of her identity and the cost of wielding power over others. The International Booker-nominated author draws on the real history of Korean soldiers who fought the Russians for the Qing Dynasty.





IN GULBADAN’S WORLD

Bābar’s daughter, the only known Mughal royal woman to have authored a surviving chronicle, records family and empire

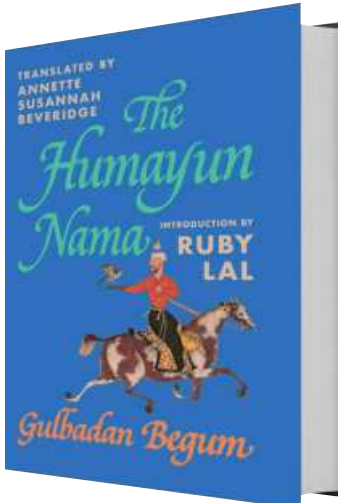
Madhulika Liddle

In 1526, Bābar defeated Ibrāhīm Lodī and established the Mughal dynasty. A few years later, having settled in India, he summoned his womenfolk – wives, daughters, aunts, etc. – from Kabul. In response to the imperial summons, there came not just the grand ladies, the *khanams* (noblewomen) and *aghachas* (junior wives), but also a little girl: six-year-old Gulbadan Begum, Bābar’s favourite daughter.

Popular history has overlooked Gulbadan, but she was to grow up and become a vital member of Akbar’s *zenana* – a matriarch who led a group of royal women on hajj – and who wrote a fascinating memoir of life as a Mughal princess.

In the late 1500s, Akbar asked Gulbadan, his aunt, to write down her memories of the dynasty’s early years. Gulbadan’s *Ahval-e-Humayun Badshah* (*The Life Conditions of Emperor Humayun*), popularly known as *The Humāyūn-Nāma*, was written in Persian. It remained unknown for several centuries, until a copy of it surfaced in 1868 in London, when the British Museum purchased a copy from the widow of a Colonel Hamilton, who had brought back a vast collection of documents from Delhi and Lucknow. It was subsequently translated into English – between 1898 and 1902 – by the Englishwoman Annette Susannah Beveridge.

Juggernaut’s edition of *The Humayun Nama* is somewhat like a set of matryoshka dolls. At its heart



The Humayun Nama
Gulbadan Begum
Trs by Annette Susannah Beveridge;
Introduction by Ruby Lal
Juggernaut
₹899

are the memories and emotions of its author, Gulbadan Begum. That memoir is brought to an English-speaking readership by Beveridge, with an introduction by yet another woman, historian Ruby Lal, whose biography of Gulbadan – *Vagabond Princess: The Great Adventures of Gulbadan* – makes her the perfect conduit for this landmark work.

Lal’s introduction is a fascinating look into the lives of both Gulbadan and her translator. She traces the life of Beveridge, her discovery of *The Humayun Nama*, and the rigorous effort that went into translating it. Despite futile attempts to find another copy of the manuscript, and Beveridge’s personal struggles

(hearing loss; the deaths of two children), the determined woman succeeded in the task she set for herself.

Part 1 of the book features a dramatis personae. Part 2 includes a highly detailed biographical account of the princess and her family; *The Humāyūn-Nāma* and a directory with biographical notes on 200 women mentioned in *The Humayun Nama*, *The Baburnama*, etc.

Unaffected, candid, insightful
At the heart of this book is Gulbadan’s work, which is a pleasure to read for her unaffected and candid style. Here was not a duty-bound, sycophantic chronicler filling her manuscript with flowery prose and profuse praise. This was a family member: privileged, strong-willed, with considerable life experience. Gulbadan was in her mid-60s when she wrote *The Humāyūn-Nāma*, and the wisdom, warmth, and humour she brings to it is entrancing.

There are descriptions here of parties and picnics; of feisty matriarchs and the often-mercurial men of Bābar’s clan. There are anecdotes – about relatives; little Akbar and his mother; and expeditions to admire the blooming of wild rhubarb in the hills around Kabul. There is even a wryly witty comment on the ways of camels, and why they make poor mounts: “Every camel which was mounted, at once, flung its rider to the ground, and took its way to the jungle...”

There is Bābar, brought vividly to life: [When one of his wives tried to dissuade him from visiting some aunts]: “His Majesty said, ‘Māham! It is astonishing that you should say such things! The daughters of Abū-sa’id Sultān Mirzā, who have been deprived of father and brothers! If I do not cheer them, how will it be done?’”

Beveridge engages the reader with her explanations, insights, and comparisons with other texts, both of Gulbadan’s period and later. She comments on what may be an oversight (or, perhaps, poor memory) on Gulbadan’s part; she explains terms – thumb rings, for instance. Through her extremely detailed notes, we see not just a very conscientious translator, but a scholar who has made it a point to study her subject very deeply. In the directory of female personalities, for example, Beveridge examines the relationships and identities of 200 women, at times diving so deep that it can become confusing for a lay reader. But for a researcher, her observations can be invaluable. Ultimately, this is a book for both the general reader and the scholar. Gulbadan’s writing is approachable and refreshing; Beveridge’s annotations are scholarly and intense. Together, they bring to life a closeted world rarely mentioned in other chronicles.

The Delhi-based reviewer is a novelist and short story writer.



‘History is part of a thinking civilisation’

Historian-authors Ruby Lal and Ira Mukhoty in an exclusive conversation on the tiger-hunting Nur Jahan

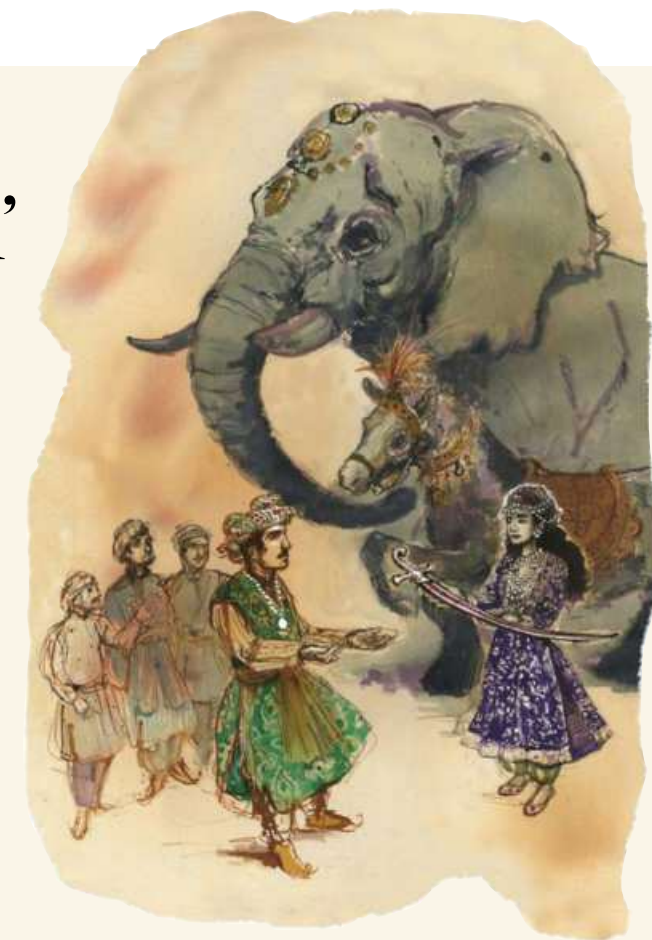
For long, historians portrayed Emperor Jahangir as weak and his chief consort Nur Jahan as manipulative. Modern scholars such as Ruby Lal reassess her as a powerful political and cultural figure. She tells the story of the Mughal world’s only female co-sovereign in *Empress: The Astonishing Reign of Nur Jahan* (2018); and in her recent *Tiger Slayer* (published by Juggernaut), illustrated by artist Molly Crabapple, for younger audiences.

Emory University (U.S.) professor Lal’s work spans genre: groundbreaking academic scholarship and biography/narrative histories (*Vagabond Princess: The Great Adventures of Gulbadan*,



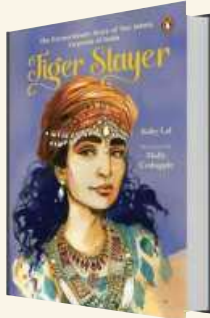
2024). Excerpts from a conversation:

Ira Mukhoty: One painting that has been instrumental in your books on Nur Jahan is of her standing with a musket preparing to hunt a tiger. And



your recent book is titled *Tiger Slayer*. Tell us about what that iconography means.
Ruby Lal: Painted by Abu’l Hasan, this is the Rampur Raza Library (Uttar Pradesh)

Her story An illustration from *Tiger Slayer*; and (left) Ruby Lal. (ILLUSTRATION: MOLLY CRABAPPLE, COURTESY JUGGERNAUT; AND MYRON B. MCGHEE)



portrait of Nur Jahan holding the musket, [an image] I’ve been obsessed with. In this painting, she’s not just holding the musket, she’s loading the musket. It tells you technical know-how, [and] war expertise. Before this, you had women represented in highly stylised *nayika* (actress) mode. In the *Jahangir-nama*, there are at least 32 mentions of Nur’s hunting. Hunting was an informal sign of sovereignty, thereby establishing her co-sovereignty. I thought for young adults, this would be an incredible incitement to think of a woman’s power, and the tiger’s majesty.

Mukhoty: Schoolchildren in India will no longer be learning

literaryreview 03

Empire in ink

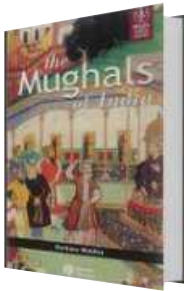
Essential reading by historians



Sohail Hashmi
Oral historian, author, conducts heritage walks

There are several texts that one could recommend but the one that comes to mind immediately is *The Mughals of India* (2023) by Prof. Harbans Mukhia, published by Blackwell Publishing. The book does not follow the traditional approaches to history writing and explores issues like policies that helped the Mughals acquire legitimacy among their subjects, what their policies on

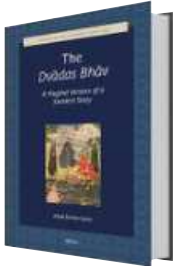
religion were, the political culture that gradually evolved through the 330-year-long Mughal reign, chapters on etiquette, court life, details of the dynamics that informed the functioning and conduct of family life among the Mughals, and Mughals in folklore, together make for a very interesting and engaging narrative.



Naman Ahuja
Art historian, curator, editor, JNU professor

Anjali Duhan-Gulia, associate professor at the department of visual arts at Maharshi Dayanand University, Rohtak, Haryana, has just authored a fascinating study titled the *Dvādas Bhāv*, a book about a manuscript by the same name that was translated for the Mughal emperor Akbar into Farsi around 1596 CE. By 1972, the manuscript had been dismembered, and its painted folios were sold to private collections and scattered all over the world.

This is the first time the text has been put back together, transcribed and translated into English. The book contextualises the *Dvādas Bhāv* within a corpus of Sanskrit works translated into Persian in Hindustan and offers insights into what went into such translations. The author shows how the illustrations that interspersed this text were intrinsic to communicating its meaning. These paintings are also studied to suggest which group of artists at the imperial atelier were responsible for their creation. The study was undertaken under the auspices of a fellowship she was awarded by the Indian Institute of Advanced Study, Shimla.



On the stands

Art magazine *Marg*’s March edition extends to temples built by the Mughals

The linguistically syncretic Mughal court commissioned Sufi poetry (*Padmavat*), imperial chronicles (*Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*), personal memoirs (*Baburnama*, *Akbarnama*). Akbar commissioned translations of Hindu religious texts, literature and epics, such as the Sanskrit *Mahabharata* into the Persian *Razmnama*, for cultural assimilation and *sulh-i-kul* (universal peace, tolerance).

Cut to now, art magazine *Marg*’s March volume, *Beyond the Mughal Arch: Temples in Early Modern Hindustan*, zooms into the temples built between the 17th and 19th centuries, in the North Indian plains. It focuses on the long influence of Mughal art and design on Indian temples; those



built by Mughal rulers and princes, their *mansabdars* or governors, and by local agents. Essays consider the imperial policies and attitudes towards temples during the reigns of Akbar, Jahangir, Shah Jahan and

Aurangzeb – asking which temples were destroyed, which continued to receive grants, and why. The volume examines construction and destruction patterns that predate Mughal rule and follow in the post-Mughal era. Taken together, the studies

paint a picture of the landmark new temples that emerged – experimental, inventive and attuned to dominant fashions – and the subsequent rise of reformist movements, such as the Nath sect and newer Bhakti cults.

about the Mughals. Your books, then, are part of the process of a pushback, of recording the fact that the Mughals existed, and in incredible ways, that women had certain powers. Were you consciously setting out to do that or was it a logical extension of your current work?

Lal: There are certain themes that have been at the heart of my thinking about the Mughals, such as itinerant lifestyle, which was very much part of the society’s ethics. It doesn’t just mean movement and migration [but] how your senses get affected by that. It’s true of all of human history, that’s how societies and situations have happened. This is not to say that there aren’t indigenous populations in places. But the experimentation and the result of that intermingling is pretty glorious. That’s what I’ve been after – the mixing, grandeur, beauty, majesty in languages, in the arts, in our sensibilities, who we are as people. Gulbadan is the most itinerant of these figures, and she’s writing about this; but how the story of Nur Jahan, the daughter of aristocratic

Persian migrants to the empire, unfolds is quite exquisite.

Tiger Slayer has acquired this political urgency because there’s a lot of interest, concern and awareness of continuing in whatever way people can. There are tonnes of student, artist and activist groups who are retelling, protecting, writing these monumental histories, and I’m definitely a part of the movement. I believe this very strongly that history is part of a thinking civilisation.

Ira Mukhoty is a writer of historical non-fiction, and her recent book is The Lion and the Lily: The Rise and Fall of Awadh (2024).



Scan QR code to read the full interview on magazine.thehindu.com

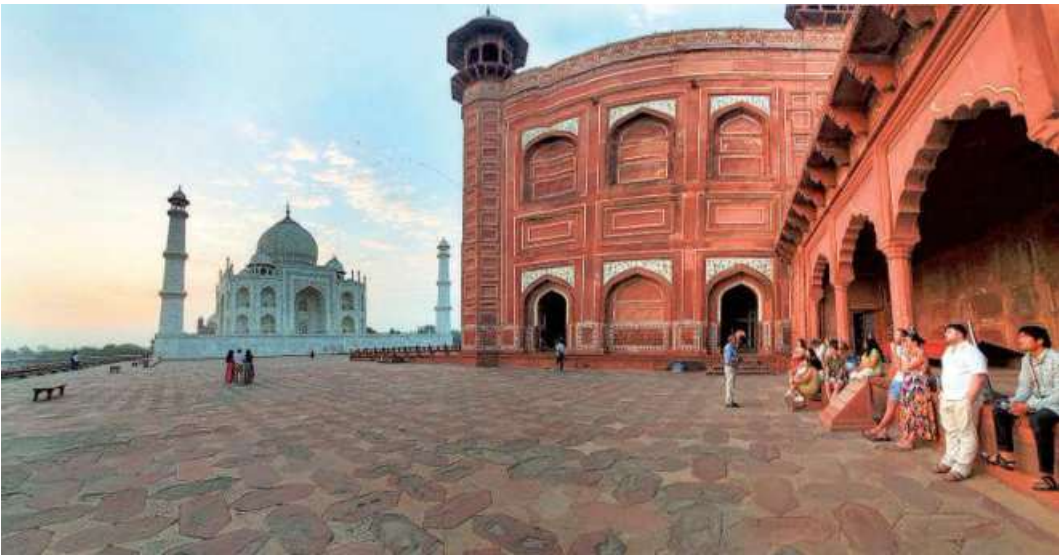
CONTINUED FROM » PAGE 1

"It is this celebration of cosmopolitanism and tolerance that is critical to understand the Mughal rule," adds Nanda. He points to the evolution of the Taj Mahal from Humayun's Tomb, with the *kalash* (finial) and *chattris* (domed kiosks) incorporated in its architectural style. Nanda speaks of administrative reforms, governance measures, the Grand Trunk Road, Princess Jahanara as a shipping magnate, and Mughal miniatures that now sell for crores in the international market. "The money, the wealth created in India, never left because the Mughals were keen to call this home."

As I step up and out of the Humayun's Tomb Museum, there are families waiting to enter the site, while others walk to Sunder Nursery, a resurrected Mughal-era garden with tombs and scattered trees, on the same premises.

The visitors don't soak in the sites, they don't look around. They fish out their phones, cameras and selfie-sticks. They want that arch, that finial, that window to frame their photograph. "People have always visited historical sites for photographs. What has changed is the number of people now visiting to make reels," says Swapna Liddle, a historian who has written books on Delhi and its monuments.

Liddle talks about the recent attempts by NCERT (National Council of Educational Research and Training) to excise chapters on Mughal history from textbooks. "But the fascination among people



LIVING WITH THE MUGHALS

has only grown. By deleting history lessons, we are making people more vulnerable to misinformation on social media," she adds.

The opulent kingdom of the Mughals stretched from Dhaka on the shores of the Bay of Bengal to Surat on the Arabian Sea coast to Arcot lower down in the Indian peninsula to Afghanistan. Between the reigns of Humayun, Akbar, Jehangir, Shah Jahan and Aurangzeb, the Mughal empire defined the physical, cultural and social dimensions of India. It became a byword for India's wealth and cosmopolitanism.

Fragments of that splendour now surface far from the subcontinent. On April 29, Sotheby's in London will auction a painting with two panels of illuminated calligraphy comprising verses of Mughal court poet Amir Khusru. This

miniature of Jehangir with courtier Asaf Khan has an opening bid of ₹1.9 crore.

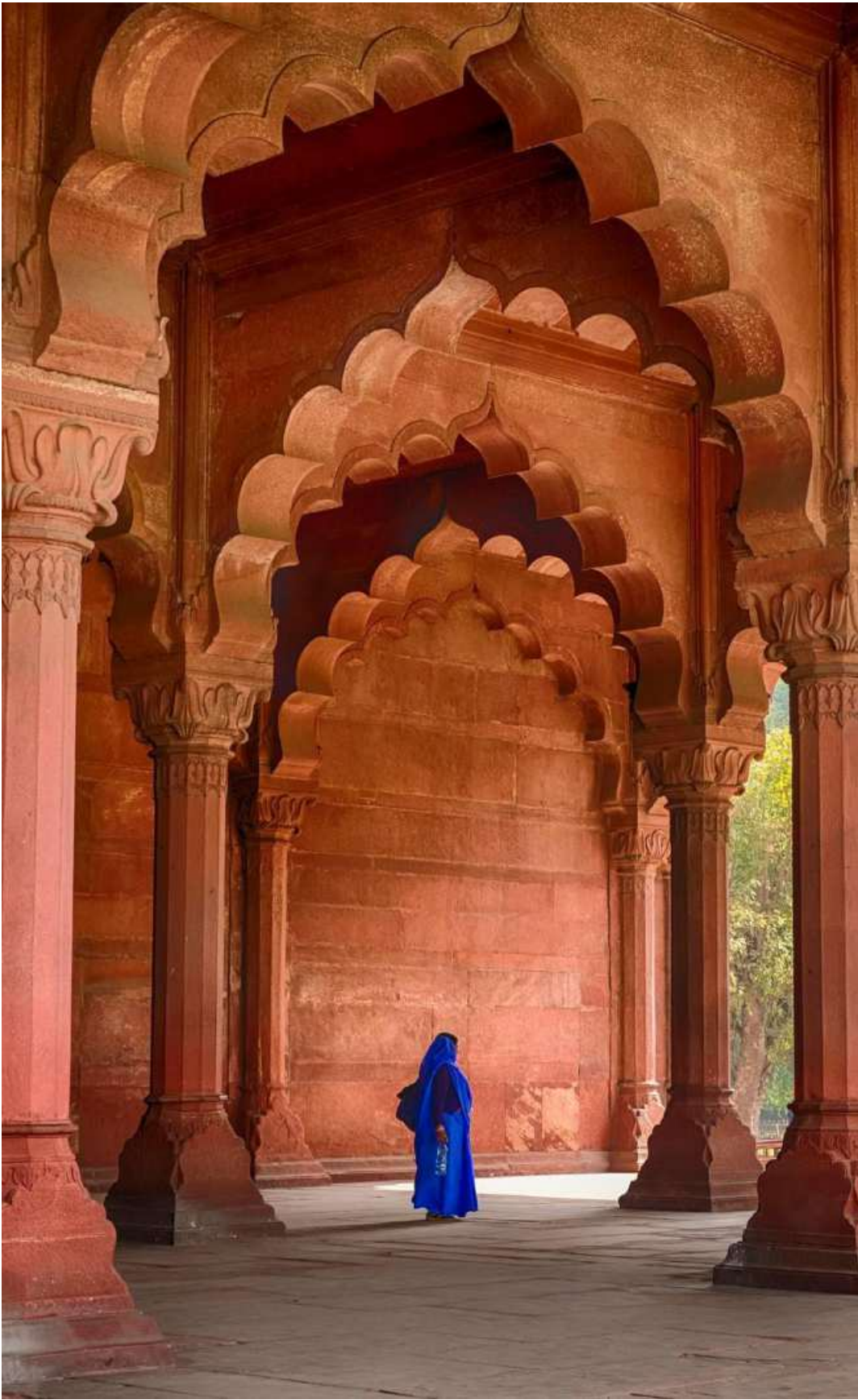
From India to the world What is it that connoisseurs understand that political mandarins often overlook? "Perhaps the most obvious example is the term 'Hindustani'. The Mughals didn't introduce the term [or the concept], but they certainly popularised both. In everyday life too, whether one is buying *sabzi* in the *bazaar*, or having *mazaa* with one's *dost*, or selecting *zawar* for a *shaadi*, you're using a lot of Persian loanwords," says Audrey Truschke, author and professor of South Asian History at Rutgers University in the U.S.

Truschke charts the history of India with the change

in language. "Hindustani predated the Mughals, as did Persian in the subcontinent. Still, the Mughal interest in both languages is certainly responsible for some of the infusion of Persian-origin terms in Hindustani. From quite early in the dynasty, the Mughal kings knew both languages, as did many *mansabdars* [high-ranking military or civil officers]," she says.

Every year on Independence Day, the Prime Minister of India unfurls the tricolour and addresses the nation from the ramparts of Red Fort. It is the same fort where Indian soldiers serving under the British unfurled their standard of rebellion and reached out to the Mughal emperor to lead the fight.

"The Red Fort has deep symbolism for India. It was built by Shah Jahan but the



(Clockwise from below) Humayun's Tomb, Red Fort and the Taj Mahal are among India's most visited historical buildings. (ANI, GETTY IMAGES, PTI)



architectural style, the material, and its location and role during the 1857 battle for Independence had deep resonance for Indian soldiers fighting against the British," says Ruchika Sharma, who teaches medieval history and runs a provocative myth-busting account on Instagram.

After the 1857 uprising, the British razed the city to the ground. Vast residential areas, barracks and shopping marts that surrounded Red Fort were flattened.

In contrast, the Mughals had turned India into their home. They transformed the country into a workshop that catered to the world. "Large halls are seen in many places, called *karkhanas* or workshops for the artisans. In one hall,

embroiderers are busily employed, superintended by a master. In another, you see the goldsmiths; in a third, painters; in a fourth, varnishers in lacquer work; in a fifth, joiners, turners, tailors, and shoe-makers; in a sixth, manufacturers of silk, brocade, and those fine muslins..." muses 17th century French physician and traveller Francois Bernier, who reached India during the peak of Shah Jahan's reign.

Muslin from Dhaka and Chittagong; craftsmen from Rajasthan; carpets and shawls from Kashmir; *kalamkari* tents from Machlipatnam; *zardozi* on saris from Varanasi; intricate embroidery; diamond traders from Gujarat; and shipping magnates from Surat – together transformed India into a global

emporium, organised along a hub-and-spoke network. The immense wealth left 17th century traders from Europe and beyond awestruck. British economist Angus Madison estimated that Mughal India's economic output rivalled that of France or England, accounting for nearly 25% of the world's GDP around 1700 CE.

"The word Mughal was synonymous with luxury and opulence. This was so because they symbolised a way of life, a heritage, a culture, which was very rich, very vibrant. Much of the cultural traditional practices we follow today, be they clothes or food, you add a 'Mughal' label and they sell. Everything is either Noor Jahan or Shah Jahan. And they are still a selling point despite being



For architecture, Akbar made a deliberate choice, clearly saying that for his new capital Fatehpuri Sikri, he chose the different styles of Gujarat and Bengal, because he was really enamoured by these Indic architectural styles, but also because they represented the extremities of his empire

RUCHIKA SHARMA Academic



Hindustani predated the Mughals, as did Persian in the subcontinent. Still, the Mughal interest in both languages is certainly responsible for some of the infusion of Persian-origin terms in Hindustani

AUDREY TRUSCHKE Author and professor of South Asian History, Rutgers University



During a heritage walk, one woman who studied at IIT, asked me about Shah Jahan cutting off the arms of workers who built the Taj Mahal... Misinformation like this will only grow if a part of history is not taught in schools

SWAPNA LIDDLE Delhi historian



The Mughals symbolised a way of life, a heritage, a culture, which was very rich, very vibrant. Much of the cultural practices we follow today, be they clothes or food, you add a 'Mughal' label and they sell

RANA SAFVI Historian



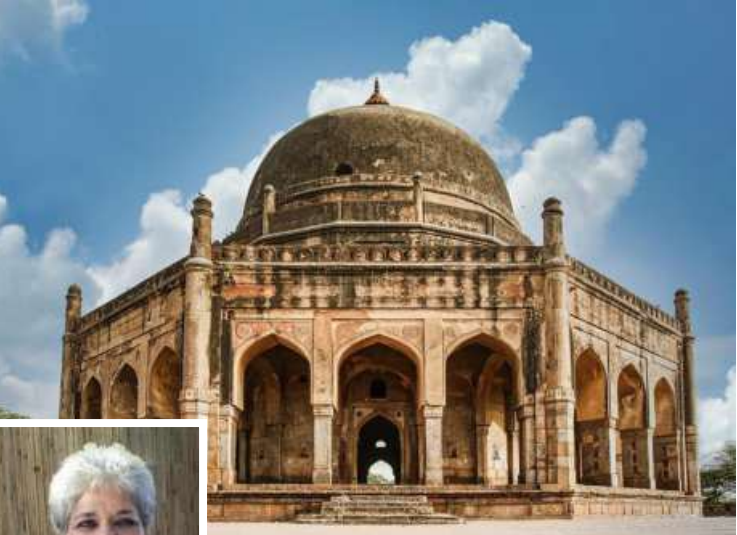
The first thing that Babur does after winning the war is not a massacre or a raid on treasury. He reaches Delhi and circumambulates the grave of Sufi saint Nizamuddin Auliya. He gets a poem inscribed on the grave of Amir Khusro there

RATISH NANDA CEO, Aga Khan Trust for Culture

abused so much," says Rana Safvi, chronicler of Mughal Delhi.

The women of the Mughal empire, right from Harkha Bai who was Akbar's partner, to Udaipuri Mahal who married Aurangzeb, played an equally important role in shaping the kingdom. Noor Jahan's mother invented *attar* (perfume) made from roses, leading to Jehangir gifting her a string of pearls. Noor Jahan designed clothes and jewellery. Her niece Mumtaz Mahal's tomb has become a global symbol of love.

Syncretic ethos Strangely, in an effort to blend in and become one with the culture of the land, Akbar did more than ban cow slaughter in the 16th century; he extended this impulse into a wide patronage of the arts. Bhakti poet Tulsiadas, author of the *Ramcharitmanas*, even used the term 'Gharib Nawaz'



LAILA TYABJI Craft activist and writer

Bhool Bhulaiya in Delhi

Since the Mughals are being written out of our history and our textbooks, where better to find them than in a *bhool bhulaiya* or maze? The one in Lucknow, at the Bada Imambara, is more famous, but Delhi has a 16th century maze of its own in Mehrauli, albeit in shocking condition.

Built in the 16th century as a tomb for Mughal general Adham Khan – Emperor Akbar's foster brother and playmate, later turned traitorous assassin – the maze's twisting dark corridors and narrow blind alleys, set in a striking domed and pillared octagon structure, are now largely in ruins or blocked up. But it still has an esoteric, mysterious charm.

Khan's actual grave was removed by a British Raj official named Blake and replaced by a dining table, when he turned the tomb into his summer residence. Blake's death, which followed soon after, was seen as divine retribution. Lord Curzon later had the graves of Khan and his mother restored to their original places.



IRA MUKHOTY Author

Palaces along Varanasi's ghats

I am always looking for texture and layers in cities I visit, especially in unusual places. Varanasi is a city that has a hidden Mughal side, which has been largely forgotten. Along the *ghats*, there are two separate palaces that are a reminder of two very different episodes in the history of the Mughals. The first structure is Raja Man Singh's palace, overlooking the Ganga. Man Singh was emperor Akbar's nephew by marriage. He became a powerful Mughal general and had this beautiful palace constructed around 1600. Today it houses a lovely museum on the culture and heritage of Varanasi. The second structure is the Chait Singh Palace. Initially used by the rajahs of Banaras till the late 18th century, it was later used as a place of exile to house the later Mughal princes and their families.



From palaces along the *ghats* of Varanasi to temples in Vrindavan and Orchha, experts share their pick of lesser-known monuments

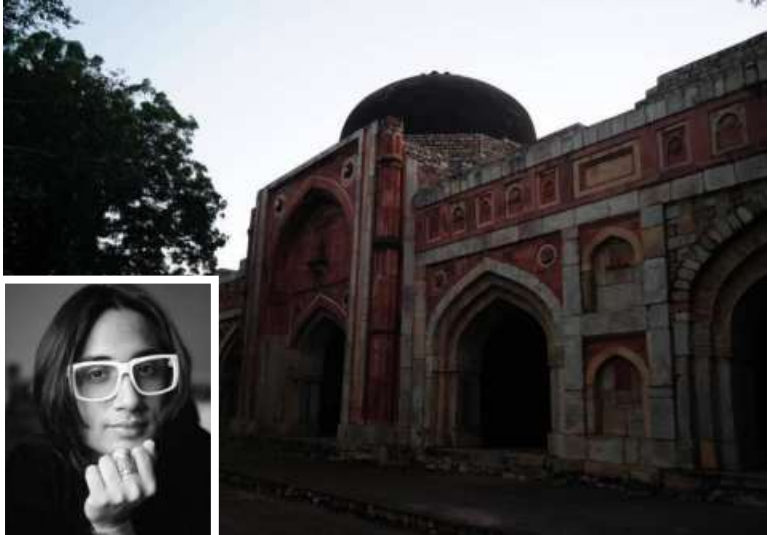
WALK A HIDDEN ROYAL TRAIL

SAM DALRYMPLE Historian and author

Govind Dev Temple in Vrindavan

For me, the most interesting Mughal era monument is the Govind Dev Temple of Vrindavan. It was built by the highest ranking *mansabdar* in the Mughal army, Man Singh of Amer, and remains one of the largest temples ever built in North India. Imperial *farmans* (royal decrees) in the National Archives show that it also received imperial patronage from Akbar.

The temple's column brackets and the prevalent use of the pointed arch are evocative of structures



ERIC CHOPRA

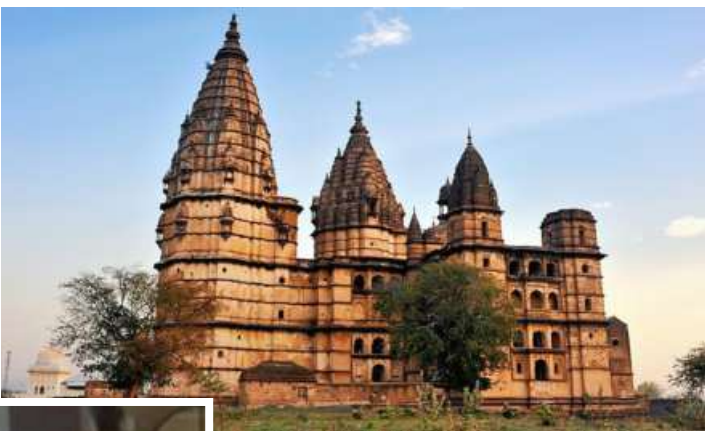
Founder of history platform Ithasology

Jamali Kamali Mosque and Tomb in Delhi

My mind drifts back to Mehrauli, Delhi's 'first' city, which the Delhi Sultanate had laid claim to. The Mughals would move closer to the Yamuna, building new cities of their own, but they never let go of Mehrauli's spiritual and political pull.

In April 1526, after Emperor Babur defeated Ibrahim Lodi, he wandered through Mehrauli. He wrote in his diary that he stopped at the tomb of Sultan Ghiyas ud-Din Balban. Today, opposite his grave in the Mehrauli Archaeological Park is the Jamali Kamali Mosque and Tomb. Delhiites would be familiar with the stories of *jinns* that supposedly inhabit this 16th century monument.

The identity of Kamali is perplexing, but the real pull is Jamali. A Sufi poet, globetrotter, and diplomat, he straddled the worlds of the Lodis and the early Mughals. Commissioned two years after the Mughal establishment, the mosque and tomb hint at the architectural splendour to come: the use of red sandstone, white marble, medallions, spandrels, niches, arches and domes.



SIMRAN AGARWAL

Assistant editor, The Marg Foundation, which is bringing out the book Beyond the Mughal Arch: Temples in Early Modern Hindustan

Temples of Bishnupur and Orchha

The monuments built by Shah Jahan are considered the finest examples of architectural elements now recognised as "Mughal style". This imperial vocabulary circulated widely across South Asia. Some of the most compelling manifestations of its use can be seen in the temples of North India's plains. In the 17th-18th centuries, after submitting to Mughal suzerainty, Bishnupur's Malla rulers built several temples. Examples include the Jor Bangla, the Ras Mancha and the Shyam Rai. Particularly interesting to me are their sloping, dome-shaped *bangla* roofs with curved eaves. This feature would soon be incorporated into the imperial architectural vocabulary, most notably in Shah Jahan's *jharokhas*.

Moving towards Central India, Orchha, under the Bundela kings, became a major centre of building activity in the Mughal period. It is home to the Chaturbhuj Temple, completed during the reign of Bir Singh Deo. Its vaulted ceilings, *iwans*-like hall and impressive 105-metre *shikhara* make it stand apart from other historic temples in the region, both in terms of scale and style.



ANIRUDH KANISETTI Historian and author

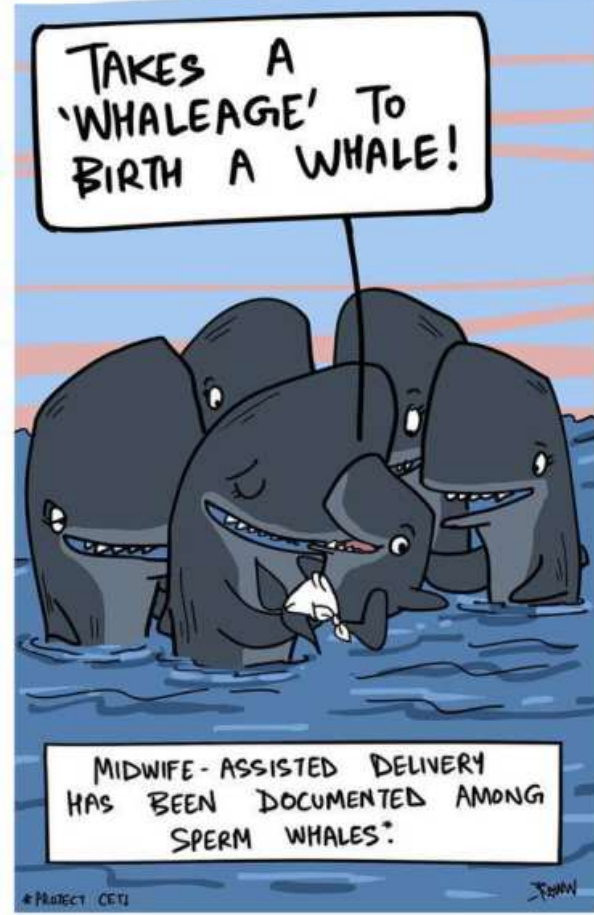
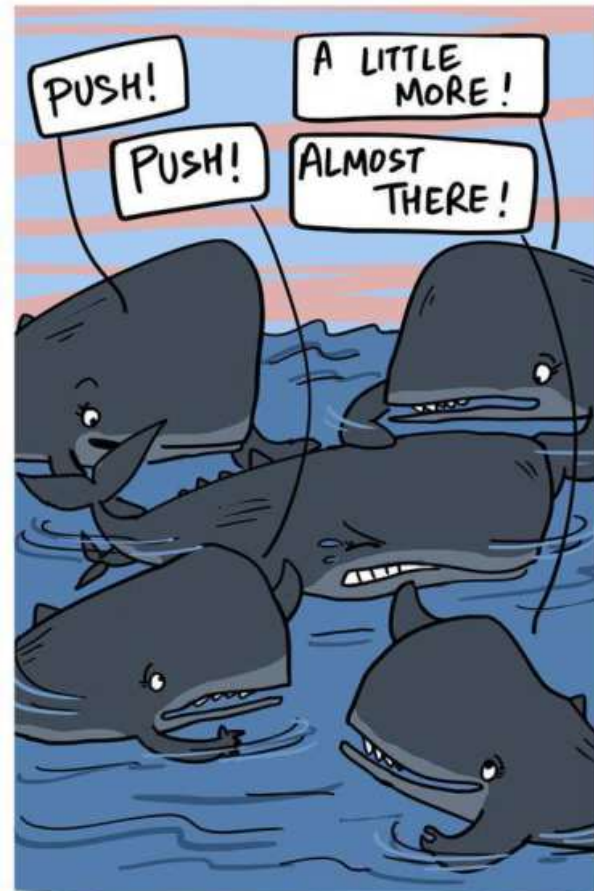
Nawab patronage

It is often as interesting to observe the fall of an empire as its rise. The 18th century saw the breakdown of successor states ruled by Nawabs. They brought with them a template of Mughal court ideas, such as cultivating relationships with Hindu pilgrimage centres. The Nawabs of Arcot, the southernmost post-Mughal power, expanded militarily into Tamil Nadu. They also extended patronage to both Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple in Srirangam and the

Sufi shrine Nathervali in Tiruchi. There is a clear parallel here to how the Mughal court made land grants to Vaishnava institutions in Braj, and encouraged their Hindu courtiers to construct temples such as the Govind Dev in Vrindavan, which was later partially demolished by Aurangzeb (a claim that is disputed now). Two decades later, when Aurangzeb conquered Hyderabad, he demolished a portion of the city built by the Qutb Shahi dynasty, and erected the Makkah Masjid, which still stands today next to the Charminar.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



A whole civilisation will die tonight never to be brought back again" U.S. President Donald Trump isn't known for his measured language. But when he issued this threat to Iran on networking platform TruthSocial, this seemed a new low.

TV anchors asked if Ronald Reagan would have said something like this. George W. Bush, back during his tenure, went out of his way to tell the Iraqi people that America's war was not against them but against Saddam Hussein's government.

The implication was that Bush was more civilised. Trump is cast as "uncivilised" because he has no qualms about saying he wants to bomb Iran back to the Stone Age. In the end though, no matter what Bush said, thousands of Iraqi civilians died in that war. Numbers vary from 180,000 to over 200,000, according to the Iraq Body Count Project.

It must have been cold comfort to those who died to know that Bush made "civilised" noises while declaring war on them on trumped-up claims against Hussein.

What Trump didn't realise as he threatened to send Iran back to the Stone Age was that Iran was actually quite a hub of the Neolithic period, transitioning from hunting/gathering to village life, domesticating goats, making terracotta figures and clay pots.

Dog-whistles to bullhorns As Indians, we know a few things about civilisation. Our history books always started with the Indus Valley civilisation and its great bath and granaries. It was a source of pride for us that we were already civilised in this part of the world when the Europeans who would one day rule over India were still living in caves. It was proof that much as the West prided itself on being the flag-bearer of civilisation, there were other civilisations too, many of them much older than the Europeans. With roads and sanitation systems. According to an essay on



Last week the U.S. president posted an AI image depicting himself as a Christ-like figure, which led to widespread backlash.

to Miyaans or Bengali Muslims, it's no longer a dog-whistle, more like a bullhorn. Himanta Biswa Sarma has said openly "...polarisation is a fight to save our identity. It is between indigenous people of Assam and illegal Bangladeshis". Politics aside, it's clear that as polarisation yields political dividends, the need to resort to dog-whistles diminishes.

Now we can have a U.S. president openly threaten the death of a civilisation and have his followers claim it's just a negotiating gambit.

Hour of the beast Perhaps it's not entirely a bad thing that Trump, whether he intended to or not, has knocked the United States off the moral high horse it likes to occupy on the global stage. Trump no longer has to pretend that the "war on terror" is about liberating oppressed women or restoring democracy. He openly says, to the "winner behind the spoils", whether it's the oil in Iran or in Venezuela.

But it still feels surreal that we are having this global conversation about civilisation, stuck between an Iranian regime that ruthlessly imprisons and executes thousands of dissenters and an American president who seems to pick war on a whim while the elite of the elite show up in the Epstein files.

The dictionary calls civilisation an "advanced state of social and cultural development, or the process of reaching this state". We seem to be blithely moving further away from it. But headed where? Or as William Butler Yeats told us over 100 years ago: *And what rough beast, its hour come round at last, Slouches towards Bethlehem to be born.*



Sandip Roy is author of Chapal Rani, the Last Queen of Bengal.

FROM CULT TO CULTURE

NARADA: THE ORIGINAL PROVOCATEUR

Hindu mythology’s impish sage has been recast through the centuries, but has never lost his identity

Who is the most chaste woman in the world,’ asked Narada. This created chaos in the heavens, especially when the sky said none was more chaste than Anasuya, wife of sage Atri. So, the three great gods went to Anasuya in the form of three handsome sages. ‘How may I serve you,’ asked Anasuya. Give us the milk of your body, they asked, knowing fully well that Anasuya was childless. But she was not hurt. She looked up at the three men as if they were her children and instantly milk flowed from her breasts and the three gods transformed into infants – her babies. This created chaos in the cosmos. The three great goddesses went to Anasuya and begged her to restore their husbands to their original form. They admitted this was a prank to test her chastity, and it had backfired spectacularly. The three gods eventually returned to the heavens with the three goddesses. They blessed the noble Anasuya with a child. On their way, they

encountered Narada who was chuckling away and chanting, ‘Narayana, Narayana!’

From gossip to grace
Narada is Hindu mythology’s impish, itinerant sage. His presence in a story spells trouble. As a character, he plays a key role. He spotlights our love for gossip, our fragile ego, our competitive spirit, our yearning to measure ourselves against others, our refusal to be content. Nara means human. Narayana means the full potential of humanity. Narada comes in between, helping humans make the journey from Nara to Narayana, by outgrowing the need to compare. Narada is a popular figure, yet we know little about him. The *Chandogya Upanishad*, dated to around 6 BCE, refers to a dialogue between two Brahmin sages on the nature of knowledge. Sage Sanatkumar tells Narada to distinguish between material knowledge that satisfies hunger and spiritual knowledge that enables contentment. Here, Narada is a seeker, aware of



learning yet aware of its limits. The more familiar lute-bearing, wandering Narada enters Sanskrit imagination in the *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana*, composed and consolidated between 4 BCE and 2 CE. He advises Yudhishthira, the eldest Pandava brother, converses with Lord Vishnu, and appears at turning points – sometimes as counsellor, sometimes as provocateur. In the *Puranas*, we are

told he was cursed for choosing not to marry and for encouraging his brothers to become monks. Condemned to wander, he becomes the eternal storyteller of Vishnu, the householder god. The *Narada Smriti*, placed between the 3rd and 5th centuries CE, situated him within the world of law and social order. The *Narada Bhakti Sutra*, between the 5 and 8 CE, reframes him as a theologian of

▲ Narada statue at the Gokarneshwor Mahadev Temple in Kathmandu; and (below) a painting at Shree Rajiv Lochan Temple in Chhattisgarh. (WIKI COMMONS)



devotion. His circulation exceeds Vaishnava space, too. In Buddhist *Jatakas*, monk Sariputta’s previous birth is called Narada. Jain traditions speak of multiple Naradas as heroic figures.

With veena in hand
Iconography follows text. The earliest surviving sculptural image appears in the Udayagiri Caves in Madhya Pradesh, in the early 5th century CE during the Gupta period. In the Varaha panel, beside Vishnu’s boar incarnation, stands Narada holding a *veena*, paired with the *gandharva* (celestial musician) Tumburu. By the late 6th century CE, in the Satruganeswar Temple in Bhubaneswar, among the earliest

structural Shaiva temples, Narada appears again in narrative relief. Between 5 and 12 CE, as temple architecture expands, Narada finds space on stone walls. In Andhra Pradesh’s Undavalli Caves, he appears seated in meditation and standing with a *tambura*. In the Chidambaram Nataraja Temple, associated with the Chola period, he stands as witness to Shiva’s cosmic dance. From 14-17 CE, during the Vijayanagara and Nayaka periods, his presence intensified within the Bhakti age. At Lepakshi Veerabhadra Temple he appears on pillars, sometimes dancing. At Parthasarathy Temple he stands serenely with a *veena*. The travelling sage becomes the patron of musical devotion. In eastern India, between the 17th and 18th centuries, a striking folk innovation appears. Terracotta panels at Joypur Dutta Para Temple and Uchkaran Char Chala Temple in West Bengal show Narada riding a *dheki*, the wooden husking pedal of agrarian life, around which women gather to gossip. The cosmic messenger is recast in rural rhythm. Across more than a millennium of sculpture, continuity and adaptation co-exist. The *veena* persists. The ascetic frame persists. The wandering posture persists. Yet settings, vehicles, and gestures change. From Gupta relief to Chola *mandapa*, from Vijayanagara pillar to Bengal terracotta, Narada evolves without losing identity.

Devdutt Pattanaik is the author of 50 books on mythology, art and culture.

Bob Jones

Today’s deal was played recently in Europe, where players experiment with bidding ideas not usually seen in North America. North’s onspade response, denying a major suit, is one such idea. North-South bid to a normal contract only to be doubled by East. This was a lead directing double, asking for the lead of

GOREN BRIDGE

Lead directing double works

Neither vulnerable, South deals

dummy’s first bid suit, in this case spades. North, with a huge unknown club fit with partner, ran to four clubs and South raised to

game. West duly led the four of spades to East’s ace, and East continued with the queen of spades to South’s king. South cashed

NORTH
♠ 9 3
♥ K 5
♦ A K 6 2
♣ K 10 6 5 4

WEST
♠ 4 2
♥ J 9 7 4
♦ Q J 10 8 4
♣ Q 9

EAST
♠ A Q J 10 7
♥ 10 3 2
♦ 7 5
♣ J 8 7

SOUTH
♠ K 8 6 5
♥ A Q 8 6
♦ 9 3
♣ A 3 2

The bidding:
SOUTH 1♣
1NT
Pass
5♣
*No major

WEST Pass
Pass
Pass
All pass

NORTH 1♠*
3NT
4♣

EAST Pass
Dbl
Pass

Opening lead: Four of ♠

the ace and king of clubs, then cashed two high diamonds and led a diamond for a ruff in his hand. East could do what

he wanted with the master trump, but he could not defeat the contract. Looking at the effect of the double, three no trump

can be made on a spade lead, but the winning line is far from clear and declarer might have gone down. Without the double, however, West would probably have led the queen of diamonds, and three no trump would have romped home, perhaps with an overtrick. In this case, the lead-directing double did no worse than break even for East-West and might have gained a little bit.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has April 19 ever given us?



▲ What was the role of Dennis Dickie Bird, who played 93 matches in first-class cricket? (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

1 On April 19, 1770, at 6 am, Captain James Cook, on board the *HMS Endeavour*, was told by his lieutenant that land had been spotted. They later landed and were met with hostility by the locals. This was the first European encounter with which country that the British eventually colonised?

2 On April 19, 1897, John J. McDermott won the first B.A.A. Road Race, which had been inspired by the success of the first marathon at the 1896 Summer Olympics. This year will be the 130th edition of which iconic marathon named after the city it is held in?

3 On April 19, 1960, Bill Veeck, owner of the baseball team Chicago White Sox, wanted to help television viewers identify players. He pioneered a practice which quickly spread to other sports the same year. What did he do that is ubiquitous in team sports uniforms nowadays?

4 On April 19, 1975, India launched a satellite into orbit from Kapustin Yar, Russia, using a Kosmos-3M rocket. Designed to conduct experiments in aeronomics and solar physics, it was named after an ancient astronomer. What did ISRO launch?

5 Born on April 19, 1912, Glenn T. Seaborg was a Nobel Prize-winning chemist who discovered 10 elements. This was his address when at work: ‘Glenn T.

Seaborg, Lawrence Berkeley Laboratory, Berkeley, California, America.’ What’s unique about this?

6 Born on April 19, 1933, Dickie Bird was a right-handed batsman who played 93 matches in first-class cricket. He was one of the few people in his profession who rose to global fame because of the 135 matches he took part in after retiring from playing. What was his role in these matches?

7 Born on April 19, 1987, this tennis player is one of just 10 women to achieve a career Grand Slam in singles. Her family had barely escaped the Chornobyl radiation that occurred a year earlier. Who is this athlete who even appeared in the film *Ocean’s 8* (2018)?

8 On April 19, 1987, biologists captured the last free-flying bird of this species in California, making the species extinct in the wild. Done to save the species from extinction due to lead poisoning, thanks to conservation programmes, there are now 276 in the wild. What majestic bird of prey is this, which gets its name from the Andean word for ‘vulture’?

9 On April 19, 2021, NASA successfully flew its drone helicopter *Ingenuity*. They proved that air 100 times less dense than normal can still support flight. What extraordinary and historic record was this?

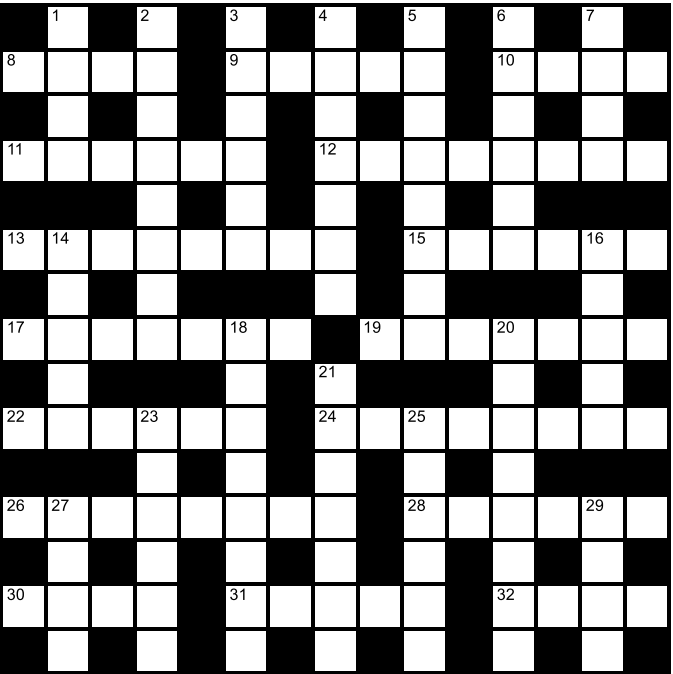
10 On April 19, 1943, Albert Hofmann ingested 250 micrograms of lysergic acid diethylamide and began noting its effects. With no car available due to wartime restrictions, he endured intense visions on his journey home. This experience is recreated worldwide on this date – on what vehicle?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 1. Austertilla
- 2. Boston Marathon
- 3. Names above the numbers on the back of the uniform
- 4. Aryabhata
- 5. Entire address can be represented using elements - Sg, Lr, Bk, Cf, Am
- 6. Umpire
- 7. Maria Sharapova
- 8. Condor
- 9. First flight on another planet - Mars
- 10. Bicycle Day

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 52 (Set by Incognito)

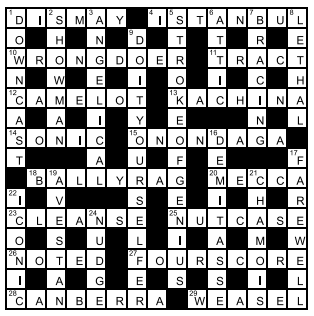


- Across**
8 Military Engineer Services gets a bit of hessian to make net (4)
9 Traverse spot marker (5)
10 Old coin for Hazare (4)
11 State: “Love actress Patani” (6)
12 Proximity from snares set behind new entrance at last (8)
13 Run away to marry, following six footer and beast (8)
15 Girl and European aristocrat disembark (3,3)
17 Nurse is transferred for commencement of day (7)
19 Surprise! Leading actor let off! (7)
22 Australian river colour (6)
24 I ogle Sue excitedly and praise (8)
26 Friend captures steed running around supporting column (8)
28 European having sex appeal is civil (6)
30 Sounds from rooms over stables (4)
31 Language used in Barbados cantonment (5)
32 Kind of bag little one gets at end of passage (4)

- Down**
1 He had consumed a top (4)
2 Wrongly crushes a hunter (8)
3 Oscar and Charlie returned tax on old size of paper (6)
4 Moment before starting slipping of satellite beneath horizon (7)
5 Spanish vehicle brought item of French cuisine (8)

- 6 Disney accepts Greek letter and edible item (6)
7 Finishes goals (4)
14 Pleasant Island urn broken! Contains gold! (5)
16 Flies modified document holders (5)
18 British permit prohibition for Americans (8)
20 Control extraordinary urge by concocting tale (8)
21 Poison made from a bit of hair under edge of dress (7)
23 After Brig. leaves, aubergines spoil resulting in discomfort (6)
25 Wolfish student is at university... next to coniferous tree (6)
27 Fencing equipment found in sheep entrails rejected (4)
29 Bird with love for Yugoslav leader (4)

SOLUTION NO. 51



How the mind keeps galloping

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It's silent and serene, but my mind is not focused enough, caught as it is in a vortex of thoughts and struggling to break free from their grip.

Like me, there are countless others sitting still like statues with closed eyes. Are they too battling with their thoughts or have they found peace at last? Some of them appear to have dozed off in the seated position, judging by the tilt of their head and a partially open mouth.

There are any number of books and guides on meditation but grasping the technique is purely a subjective one. Ironically, the more we try, the more it eludes us. One may start the exercise by observing the breath but for how long? Before we know it, a stray thought pops up out of the blue and this leads to another one and next, and latches on to some more with a cascading effect. Our breathing is all but forgotten. It takes me only a split second, to wander off to another part of the continent wondering about the current geopolitical scenario in the world and whether the cooking gas cylinder I have ordered will be delivered on time. In effect, I was there, but never quite there!

In a sense, our mind could be compared to a mini social media platform overflowing with information, evaluation, comparisons, and misconceptions. The only subject here is the self with multiple voices. At any given point of time, there is a churn going on back and forth of ideas, judgments, comments – all happening with lightning speed like data transfer within the small globe of our head.

According to psychologists, the mind thrives in negativity. It's the reason we are more obsessed with our enemies and rivals than our friends and well-wishers. While preoccupied with the former's "misdeeds", a resultant wave of emotions such as anger, hate, fear, guilt, and sadness rage inside us. In a way, it affects our breathing pattern too as the mental chatter ends in accumulating a lot of mental clutter. Here, we are quite aware that to maintain equilibrium, we need to declutter the mind of negativities the way we detox our body once in a while to clear the ill-effects of junk food. Alas, there's no shortcut like "clear chat" or "delete" button to erase the unwanted files and messages from our mind. We do have a better option and here is where the practice of meditation gains importance. As we ponder, we do get an idea about certain key factors that hamper our progress in meditation. Our high level of expectations from everyone including ourselves combined with a low sense of acceptance of the actual state of affairs trap us in our own thoughts.



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'Be realistic, demand the impossible'
– May 1968 protest slogan

At a moment when the world once again teeters on the edge of catastrophic conflict, I find myself returning to the memory of another time in the 1960s, when dissent was not only possible but transformative. Today, as war rhetoric escalates, and the language of power grows increasingly unrestrained, I am struck by the absence of a comparable collective moral force.

I came of age in the mid-1960s, entering my undergraduate years at a time when the world seemed alive with argument, possibility, and resistance. Unlike the present, the university was a space charged with debate and intellectual exchange. We did not simply inherit the world, we interrogated it. But just as formative as the university were the informal spaces we inhabited. The coffeehouse culture of those years, the dimly lit rooms filled with cigarette smoke, the clattering cups, and restless voices, became an extension of intellectual life. It was there that ideas found their urgency. Conversations moved from literature to politics, from philosophy to the daily headlines of war and protest. Democracy, freedom, and human rights, far from being abstract concepts were debated intensely, often passionately.

Music, theatre, and radical thought became some of the most powerful carriers of this spirit of interrogation. Sitting with friends, often late into the night, we read the incendiary writings of Jean-Paul Sartre and Herbert Marcuse, whose critiques of consumer capitalism and conformity unsettled our certainties. Their insistence that modern societies could produce not freedom but new forms of domination forced us to rethink the very meaning of democracy. At the same time, the political courage of figures like Martin Luther King Jr., with his uncompromising stand against racial injustice, and Malcolm X, with his fierce articulation of dignity and resistance, expanded our sense of what dissent could achieve. These were not distant figures; they were intellectual and moral presences

When resistance became memory

Today, as the world confronts violence and failure of conventional political mechanisms, the question is whether the dissenting spirit of the 1960s can return

that shaped our conversations, compelling us to confront power, inequality, and the ethical responsibilities of citizenship.

The global context reinforced this awakening. The protests against the Vietnam War revealed the extent to which state power could be mobilised in the name of abstract ideological goals, often at immense human cost. The Woodstock Festival became, for many of us, a symbolic convergence of resistance and community, a fleeting but powerful vision of an alternative social order.

Yet it was not confined to any one nation. The upheavals of 1968 unfolded as a truly global phenomenon, with students and young people rising across continents in a shared moment of defiance. From the campuses of University of California, Berkeley, where earlier movements for free speech had already unsettled authority, to the streets of Mexico City, where students challenged state repression at great personal cost, and to universities across Germany and Italy, where entrenched hierarchies were openly contested, a pattern of resistance emerged that was unmistakably international. These movements were not identical in form or demand, yet they were united by a refusal to accept inherited structures of power.

Understandably, there was a seriousness of engagement that feels strikingly absent today. The lessons that I have learnt in my lifetime are that we cannot be neutral, and that history has no bystanders but

participants. Change happens not because of what our leaders decide but how mass movements force them to act responsibly and justly.

In the present moment, the scale of global anxiety, particularly around war, will seem to demand a comparable response. Yet dissent often appears fragmented, mediated through digital platforms that amplify outrage but rarely sustain it. The physicality of protest, the gathering of bodies in shared space, has, in many contexts, given way to more dispersed forms of expression, though, in the past few days, millions took to the streets sporadically. There is anger, but it lacks the cohesion that once enabled movements to exert pressure.

What I remember most from my youth is not simply the scale of protest, but the depth of conviction. We argued, read, and reflected in classrooms, in streets, and in those crowded coffeehouses where ideas seemed to gather a life of their own. Dissent became a process, a habit. Today, as the world confronts renewed cycles of violence and the failure of conventional political mechanisms, the question is whether such a spirit can return. Though the conditions have changed, the underlying impulse, the refusal to accept the inevitability of injustice, remains as urgent as ever.

The memory of the 1960s reminds me that such moments are possible. They require not only outrage but also imagination and commitment. The challenge is to rediscover that depth, to move beyond the immediacy of reaction toward forms of engagement that can endure. Albert Camus was spot on when he said, "The only way to deal with an unfree world is to become so absolutely free that your very existence is an act of rebellion."

The wind, as Dylan once sang, is still blowing.



Protests require not only outrage but also imagination and commitment

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Behind the closed doors of India's most affluent neighbourhoods lies a paradox of modern life – elderly parents who have every financial comfort, yet suffer from a profound poverty of the soul.

During my tenure as Commandant of the Army Base Hospital in Delhi, care was institutional, structured, and absolute; we left no one behind. Over the past few months, making home visits to nearly 100 elderly patients across the National Capital Region, I have witnessed a starkly different reality. In the civilian urban landscape, I rarely encountered poverty. Instead, I found a profound, silent epidemic: loneliness.

India is ageing rapidly, with nearly 150 million people above the age of 60 – a number projected to double by 2050. Yet, societal infrastructure has not kept pace with medical longevity.

Society clings to the myth of the joint family, assuming that because an elderly parent lives in the same house, they are cared for. The reality of modern nuclear families, driven by economic pressures and urban

Aged and lonely

It's an unfortunate modern-day reality in affluent urban landscapes across India



All alone The elderly feel a growing isolation in many urban nuclear families across the country. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

lifestyles, tells a different story. In upper-middle-class homes, elderly parents are often provided a room, a domestic helper, and arranged meals. Their financial needs are met, but emotional needs are starved.

Institutionalised neglect Sometimes, this neglect is subtly institutionalised within the home. One occasionally hears of elderly parents being sent to the neighbourhood park with a packed lunch,

gently instructed not to return until evening so the younger household members can manage their busy schedules undisturbed.

In another instance, I treated a bedridden stroke survivor whose son manages a business overseas. The primary caregiver is the patient's equally frail wife, aided by hired help.

Financially secure? Yes. But one must ask: is this truly care, or simply the most efficient compromise modern

life allows? I have come across the elderly single parent living alone on a separate floor of the same multi-storey building with occasional visit by the son or daughter-in-law.

In contrast to the growing isolation in many urban nuclear families, rural India still retains, to a considerable extent, the traditional joint family structure. Though modern economic pressures and changing lifestyles have placed this system under strain, it continues to function as an important social support network. In many villages, elderly parents remain within the household, surrounded by children, daughters-in-law, and grandchildren, and are often treated with respect and a sense of duty rooted in long-standing cultural values. While disagreements and generational differences certainly occur, the joint family system still provides a framework in which the elderly are rarely left entirely alone, offering them a continuing sense of belonging in the later years of life.

We cannot simply outsource the dignity of our elders to untrained domestic staff. India has a severe shortage of specialised geriatric care, both doctors and nurses; a visit from a

general practitioner is not a substitute for comprehensive senior support. Furthermore, premium assisted living facilities remain expensive, while affordable options lack basic medical infrastructure.

Ageing is a societal responsibility, not just a familial burden. We need innovative, community-based solutions. One such model is the "Time Bank", successfully implemented in countries such as Switzerland, where young individuals volunteer time to assist the elderly, banking those hours for their own use when they inevitably age. We must also normalise community living among cohorts of friends or colleagues, designing housing that supports mutual care.

There are virtually no emergency medical care system for the elderly even in most urban high-end housing societies, when time is the most crucial factor in saving a life. Metropolitan hospitals have started parking an ambulance in such societies to build up their clientele as these ambulances transport the patient to their hospital.

Longevity without dignity is a hollow victory. As a society, we must confront a profound question: are we prepared to build a world fit for the generation that built ours?



FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

▼ Cover story

GLP-1 drugs, originally for diabetes, are now widely used for weight loss and for improving insulin response. ('Hunger has left the chat'; April 12) However, their future lies in broader metabolic therapies, but concerns over cost, accessibility and misuse for cosmetic weight loss remain.

N.S. Reddy



Drugs like Semaglutide have revolutionised the treatment of type 2 diabetes and obesity. It is important that our government and regulators ensure quality generics are licensed and affordable, so this breakthrough becomes a public health revolution, and not restricted to the affluent.

H.N. Ramakrishna



The popularity of semaglutide reflects a deeper discomfort with the discipline that good health demands. In a country grappling with the "thin-fat" paradox, the temptation to outsource health to injections is understandable, but misplaced. Using these drugs for rapid results, even for weddings, trivialises medicine and normalises dependency.

Harsh Pawaria



Ozempic is intended for an adjustment, not as replacement of a healthy diet. Regular exercise is important. To prevent muscle-loss, experts recommend focusing on high quality nutrients and adequate protein intake.

K.M.K. Murthy



Re-discovering Delhi
Neha Sinha's endeavour to highlight the least



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Yesudas Pillai

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Ruchi Tripathi

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Chanchala Borah

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R. Bhaskar

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